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Course Section: BA 360-03 (1755) - Introduction to Operations and Supply Chain Management

Company's Name: Casey's General Stores, Inc.

Two Noteworthy Topics: Supply Chain Management and Inventory Management

Executive Summary

Company Overview

Casey's General Stores, Inc. combines fuel, grocery merchandise, and restaurant-style prepared food. As of April 30, 2026, it operated 2,944 stores in 19 states, with approximately 71% located in communities of fewer than 20,000 residents. Fiscal 2026 revenue was \$17.56 billion, and Casey's identifies itself as the nation's third-largest convenience retailer and fifth-largest pizza chain (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2026a, 2026b). Its small-market footprint makes reliable logistics and precise store-level inventory essential.

Noteworthy Practice 1: Supply Chain Management

Casey's most noteworthy supply-chain practice is its company-controlled distribution backbone. Distribution centers in Ankeny, Iowa; Terre Haute, Indiana; and Joplin, Missouri receive electronic store orders and replenish locations through company-operated trucks and route optimization. Most stores are within an efficient-service radius of roughly 500 miles; farther locations may use third-party distribution. Casey's also owns a Texas fuel terminal, self-distributes most fuel, and operated more than 500 tractors at fiscal year-end (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2026a).

This network gives Casey's control over availability, delivery frequency, transportation cost, food safety, and standardized product rollouts across dispersed towns. Direct manufacturer purchasing can improve buying power, while supplier standards promote consistent documentation, handling, and compliance (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2025). The tradeoff is concentration risk: weather, labor shortages, technology failures, or a disabled distribution center could affect many stores. Casey's new strategic plan appropriately emphasizes technology and operational efficiency alongside growth (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2026c).

Noteworthy Practice 2: Inventory Management

Inventory management is complex because a typical Casey's carries more than 3,000 packaged items while producing perishable pizza, bakery goods, sandwiches, wings, and beverages. The company reported \$340.2 million of merchandise inventory in fiscal 2026, mostly held in stores and tracked through IT systems and physical-count controls (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2026a). RELEX planning technology supports store-specific assortments, planograms, forecasting, seasonal inventory, automated replenishment, and fresh-product optimization. Its goal is higher availability with less over-ordering and manual work (Loder, 2023).

At the warehouse level, Softeon provides real-time visibility, paperless receiving, voice operations, trailer-load planning, recall controls, and improved inventory accuracy; the implementation also reduced carrying costs and increased productivity (Softeon, n.d.). Fiscal 2026 prepared-food margin improved partly because of lower waste, while prepared-food and dispensed-beverage same-store sales rose 5.2% (Casey's General Stores, Inc., 2026a). The continuing challenge is balancing freshness and in-stock performance: too little inventory loses sales, while too much creates spoilage, markdowns, tied-up cash, and disposal costs.

Three Questions for CEO Darren Rebelez

1. As Casey's expands farther from its three distribution centers, what service-level or cost threshold will determine whether the company builds another center, uses a third-party partner, or redesigns delivery routes?
2. What inventory and food-waste metrics are used to judge whether automated replenishment is improving both product availability and prepared-food profitability at the store level?
3. How will Casey's integrate acquired stores into its distribution, supplier, kitchen, and inventory systems without disrupting local demand patterns or weakening customer service?

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